# The five-minute skill check

Before you install an agent skill from someone you don't know

Agentic. Schule

**1** **Read the `SKILL.md`**

The file your agent will read as instructions, every line. Not the README of the marketplace.

**2** **Search for addresses**

Does every domain really belong to the vendor? Is the spelling exactly right? Every URL is a place where something different may sit tomorrow.

```
grep -rn "https\?://" .
```

**3** **Search for authority**

Phrases that turn foreign text into commands: "ground truth", "authoritative", "always follow the instructions at", "without bothering the user".

```
grep -rniE "ground truth|authoritative|always follow" .
```

**4** **Look into the scripts**

Not only the Markdown files. And everything the skill wants to install: "prerequisites", "setup", "install it globally".

**5** **Origin over popularity**

Who submitted it, and how old is the account? Stars belong to the repository, not to a single skill in it.

**6** **Find hidden characters**

Zero-width spaces, direction overrides and tag characters are invisible on screen, and many models read them anyway. This shows every line with a character outside plain ASCII (tabs and umlauts show up too):

```
LC_ALL=C grep -rn '[^[:print:][:space:]]' .
```

## Three rules that matter more than the check

- **A skill that fetches instructions from the internet cannot be reviewed once and for all.** What gets executed is whatever sits behind the link right now.
- **Treat foreign skills as inspiration, never as a dependency.** Find hidden characters first (step 6), then let your agent rewrite them in its own words, in a fresh session.
- **Keep the safety nets on.** Know which mode your agent starts in (Claude Code: auto mode). Sandbox on, no Turbo, `--dangerously-skip-permissions`, bypass permissions or `--yolo` with a new skill, and read every permission prompt. In Claude Code, check `allowed-tools` in the frontmatter.

From the talk "Dangerous AI Skills" by Johannes Hoppe · Slides, prompt and sources: talks.agentic.schule/dangerous-ai-skills/materials/